

# 8

## Further Objections

In the last three chapters, I have addressed three of the most prominent objections to intuitionism, those concerned with intuitionism's ability to account for moral knowledge, its ability to explain and resolve moral disagreement, and its ability to account for moral motivation. In this chapter, I address miscellaneous further objections.

### 8.1 The argument from weirdness

I begin with J. L. Mackie's famous contention that objective moral properties would be 'queer'.<sup>1</sup> This objection is voiced in conversation more often than it is put in writing. Philosophers often dismiss moral realism, intuitionism, and many other views as too 'weird', 'spooky', or 'mysterious' for them.<sup>2</sup> This may well be the main source of resistance to intuitionism. No matter how forcefully I make the rest of the arguments in this book, intuitionism will never be accepted as long as philosophers find it 'weird'.

Mackie had a few specific things to say about *how* moral properties would be queer that I will not discuss in this section, as they are dealt with elsewhere.<sup>3</sup> Here, my focus is his general contention that moral properties would be properties 'of a very strange sort, utterly different from anything else in the universe'.<sup>4</sup>

Anti-realists may be right in pegging objective values as strange. But how would this be a reason for denying their existence? Perhaps the argument is:

1. Objective values would be weird.
2. If something would be weird, then it (probably) does not exist.
3. Therefore, objective values (probably) do not exist.

What does it mean for something to be 'weird'? This might seem a frivolous question, were it not for the enormous influence that the sense of 'weirdness' has on what positions are respected and seriously investigated in philosophy. Consider four interpretations of the notion:

*First:* Perhaps to say a kind of thing is weird is to say that it is *counter-intuitive* that things of that kind exist. But Mackie does not accept intuition as a justification for believing (or disbelieving) anything, so this is an unlikely interpretation. And if Mackie *did* accept the validity of intuition, then we could simply appeal to the various intuitions cited in this book to show that objective values exist. Since Mackie thinks a claim to objectivity is embedded in all ordinary moral thinking and discourse,<sup>5</sup> the case that objectivism is counter-intuitive would be a tough one to make.

*Second:* Perhaps to say  $x$  is weird is to say that  $x$  is very dissimilar from all or most other things that exist. In this case, premise (2) becomes: 'If something is very dissimilar from other things that exist, then it (probably) does not exist'. Why should we accept this? Consider this partial list of what exists:

|               |                                        |
|---------------|----------------------------------------|
| time          | mental states                          |
| space         | physical states                        |
| numbers       | aesthetic properties                   |
| propositions  | fields (e.g., the gravitational field) |
| substances    | the past                               |
| properties    | dispositional properties               |
| relationships | moral properties                       |

One could say of any item on that list that it is utterly different from everything else that exists. At least it seems that way, and yet all those things seem clearly to exist. This isn't just the trivial point that everything is different from everything else; the point here is that the above things are each *very* different, different in kind, from everything else. So, on the face of it, this version of the argument from weirdness goes nowhere.

*Third:* Perhaps anti-realism about weirdness is correct. Perhaps 'weirdness' is the property of causing some sort of reaction in human observers, such as surprise, wonder, or disbelief; perhaps ' $x$  is weird' expresses a non-cognitive reaction towards  $x$ ; or perhaps there simply

is no such thing as weirdness. If *moral* anti-realism is true, then I think anti-realism about *weirdness* is almost certainly true. But then it is very unclear how calling something weird could count as giving evidence against its existence.

*Fourth:* Perhaps to say something is weird is to say we do not clearly understand its nature. This would be a version of the third interpretation, and the same objection applies: it is unclear how our failure to clearly understand something is evidence against its existence. Nor do I see reason, in any case, for thinking we do not understand moral properties reasonably well.

On this score, the anti-realist might point to intuitionists' failure to explain the nature of moral properties. But intuitionists have said many things about the nature of moral properties—that goodness is an objective property; that it depends on but is not reducible to the natural properties of a thing; that it comes in degrees; that awareness of it intrinsically provides us with reasons for action; that it is the opposite of badness; that things which have it are appropriate objects of such attitudes as approval and admiration; that it is a property that such things as happiness, knowledge, benevolence, and honesty have in common.

Still, the anti-realist might point to intuitionists' failure to *define* moral concepts. But this is no reason for denying that we understand moral concepts, nor for denying that they refer to anything. We often understand a concept well enough to know that it applies to some things, without being able to define it. I cannot define 'table', and I don't believe I have ever met anyone who could.<sup>6</sup> But I still know there are tables. For a more interesting example, analytic philosophers have tried for 40 years to define 'knowledge', but no definition has been generally accepted, and in my view, every definition proposed is subject to decisive counter-examples. But no one thinks this proves that we don't understand 'knows' or that it doesn't apply to anything. Indeed, my own view is that no correct, non-stipulative definition of *any* philosophically interesting concept has ever been produced. Obviously, I cannot show that here, but I can report that I know of no such definition that has been *generally accepted* in any branch of philosophy. The intuitionists' inability to define 'good', therefore, hardly shows goodness to be queer in a way that justifies denying its existence.

## \*8.2 Troubles with supervenience

### \*8.2.1 Mackie's objection

All or nearly all realists agree that moral properties depend on non-moral properties. For example, if Pol Pot is evil, there must be something else *about* him that *makes* him evil—say, his disregard for human life, his tyrannical personality, and so on. And whatever this property or collection of properties is, any other person who had it would also thereby be evil. We express this idea by saying that moral properties ‘supervene on’ non-moral properties.<sup>7</sup>

J. L. Mackie finds this dependence of moral properties on non-moral properties mysterious:

What is the connection between the natural fact that an action is a piece of deliberate cruelty—say, causing pain just for fun—and the moral fact that it is wrong? It cannot be an entailment, a logical or semantic necessity. Yet it is not merely that the two features occur together. The wrongness must somehow be ‘consequential’ or ‘supervenient’; it is wrong because it is a piece of deliberate cruelty. But just what *in the world* is signified by this ‘because’?<sup>8</sup>

He goes on to worry that our awareness of this relationship would require a mysterious ‘intuition’. Apart from that, the above quotation is the entire exposition of the objection.

*Pace* Mackie, I do not believe that the above passage articulates any objection to moral realism at all. I see nothing there that provides a reason for denying that a property can depend on other properties. Mackie has identified nothing problematic about this relation; all he says about it is that it is not logical or semantic entailment. The rest of the passage’s content seems to consist of a tone of incredulity.

Perhaps Mackie’s idea is that this dependence relation is queer, just as moral properties are, or that intuitionists’ failure to define it is a reason for denying that it exists. If so, my replies in section 8.1 apply.

However, I do not deny that there are philosophical puzzles concerning supervenience; we shall see some in the following subsections.

### \*8.2.2 Objections to the notion of *prima facie* rightness

Some intuitionists, myself included, believe that our intuitions tell us, not that certain kinds of action are always right, but that certain kinds of action are *prima facie* right. A *prima facie* right type of action is a type of action that *tends* to be right, or is morally right *other things being equal*.<sup>9</sup> The reason for introducing this notion is that all or most of the generalizations we can think of about what is right or wrong have exceptions. For instance, it is generally wrong to burn cats. But if the cat had a deadly, contagious disease, and the microbes could only be killed by burning, then it would be alright to burn a cat. Furthermore, it proves exceedingly difficult to state all the conditions under which cat-burning would be permissible. So some intuitionists say that we can merely see that causing suffering is *prima facie* wrong—it is wrong as long as no special exculpatory or justificatory circumstances exist.

Peter Strawson objects that this idea conflicts with the original idea that the moral properties of a thing follow from its non-moral properties. If *B* follows from *A*, then *B* must be present whenever *A* is, not merely ‘tend to be’ present when *A* is, or be present *most* of the time when *A* is. Furthermore, to say a type of action ‘tends to be wrong’ is just to say that *most* actions of that kind are wrong. But a statement of the form ‘Most *A*’s are *B*’ cannot be a necessary truth. Yet intuitionists claim the basic moral truths to be necessary.<sup>10</sup>

This objection has a few false premises. Intuitionists think that the moral status of an action follows from the *total set* of its non-moral properties, not from any one *prima facie* right-making or wrong-making feature. Nor does ‘Cat-burning is *prima facie* wrong’ mean ‘Most cat-burnings are wrong’. It means that an act’s being a case of cat-burning counts against that action; it is logically compatible with this that *most* of the time there *do* exist exculpatory circumstances. (Imagine that most of the world’s cats had a deadly disease, etc.)<sup>11</sup>

To see that this conception of *prima facie* rightness is perfectly coherent, compare an example from classical physics. Newton tells us that a body will accelerate in the direction of the net force acting on it. He also gives us a law of gravity governing *one* of the forces that acts on bodies. It is physically necessary that a massive body experience a gravitational pull—something that has a tendency to accelerate it—towards any other massive body. If there are no other forces, then the body will accelerate in that direction. But there may be other forces, such as electric or magnetic ones, that overcome that pull.

*Prima facie* rightness and wrongness are analogous to ‘forces’ that

pull an action towards rightness or wrongness.<sup>12</sup> Just as, in classical physics, the acceleration of any body is determined by the physical configuration of the system it belongs to, so the rightness or wrongness of actions is determined by their non-moral features (including relational features). Just as it is physically necessary that a given configuration generates a certain amount of gravitational force, it is (metaphysically) necessary that a given non-moral property generates a certain degree of *prima facie* wrongness. Just as the law of gravity does not mean that *most* objects are falling (perhaps most are being supported by counter-balancing forces), the principle of the *prima facie* wrongness of cat-burning does not mean that most cat-burnings are wrong.

Admittedly, this analogy is misleading in at least two ways. First, in the case of classical physics, there is a simple mathematical law for the composition of forces (that is, how to compute 'total force' when given the individual forces): the parallelogram law. I do not mean to suggest that the law for the composition of *prima facie* rightnesses and wrongnesses (the principle that takes you from the various right-making and wrong-making features of an action to its overall degree of rightness or wrongness) is similar in form to the parallelogram law for the composition of forces, nor indeed that it has any simple mathematical formulation. The only point here is that there is nothing incoherent in the general framework of *prima facie* duties.

Second, in classical physics, a force can be outweighed by a greater force, but it cannot be removed when the conditions specified in the relevant force law obtain. For instance, gravitational force can be *counterbalanced*, but there is no way to *remove* the gravitational force a body experiences, as long as the body is in the vicinity of another massive body. In contrast, moral considerations may be not only counterbalanced, but also removed. For example, assume that it is *prima facie* right to make people happy. But now suppose that some particular act would produce happiness for a sadist by allowing him the pleasure of watching other people suffer. In this case, the point is not merely that the value of the sadist's pleasure is *outweighed* by the suffering of his victims; rather, the sadistic nature of the enjoyment to be produced deprives it of *any* moral value. The sadist's pleasure is not a reason *at all* in favor of the proposed action.<sup>13</sup>

Now, one might think that this creates a problem for the very notion of *prima facie* rightness. Suppose that a *prima facie* right type of action is understood to be a type of action such that an act's being of that type counts as a reason in its favor. The sort of example we have just discussed shows that it is difficult to find any type of action such that an act's being of that type is *always* a reason in its favor—

there can always, it seems, be further circumstances that neutralize any would-be reason in favor of an action.<sup>14</sup>

There are at least two ways we might respond to this. On the one hand, we might say that this sort of example only shows that one has misidentified what is *prima facie* right: it is not the production of happiness that is *prima facie* right, we might say, but the production of *innocent* pleasures. Alternately, we might simply liberalize the notion of *prima facie* rightness: we might say that when a type of action is *prima facie* right, then we have a reason to perform acts of that type *other things being equal*, or *in normal conditions*; this is compatible with the possibility of special circumstances that would neutralize this reason. Of course, we have not hereby produced a satisfactory moral theory—to do that, we would have to say much more, about such matters as which things are *prima facie* right and which sorts of considerations neutralize which sorts of reasons. All I am aiming at here is to defend intuitionism against the charge that it has available no coherent notion of how moral properties are related to natural properties.<sup>15</sup>

Consider a second analogy. No one doubts that there are objective facts about what is a good move in chess—not morally good, but good from the standpoint of winning and not losing the game. Whether a move is good supervenes on the arrangement of pieces on the board (perhaps together with the capacities of the players). There are rules that help one choose good moves: try to develop your pieces early, try to control the center of the board, rooks are more valuable than knights, and so on. All these rules are defeasible; some possible positions call for violating them. Nevertheless, these principles can be seen, rationally, to be correct. A person with no experience playing chess but who knew the rules and objective of the game could see that these things make sense.<sup>16</sup> Furthermore, they are necessary truths. (It is contingent what the rules of the game are, but *given* these rules, it is necessary, in a manner similar to mathematical truths, that these rules represent generally good strategies.<sup>17</sup>)

This analogy refutes Strawson's contention that it cannot be necessary that some class of things *tend* to have some property. And it demonstrates the coherence of the intuitionist's conception of the relationship between evaluative and natural facts. It does not show that conception to be *correct*—perhaps morality is not like chess—but it shows the conception to be coherent, by showing that there actually exists a realm in which the facts and our reasoning about them exemplify the structure the intuitionist attributes to moral facts and moral reasoning.

### \*8.2.3 Blackburn's objection

Let  $A$  be some act which is morally wrong. Let  $N$  be the complete set of natural properties of  $A$ .<sup>18</sup> According to Blackburn, proposition (2) below is analytically true, but (1) is not:

1. If  $A$  has  $N$ , it is wrong.
2. If  $A$  has  $N$  and is wrong, then every action that has  $N$  is wrong.

In other words, you can coherently hold (without thereby proving that you don't understand the concept of wrongness), 'A has  $N$  but isn't wrong'. But you cannot coherently hold, 'A has  $N$  and is wrong, but other things with exactly the same natural properties are not wrong'. Blackburn thinks that the realist cannot explain this. If wrongness is some extra property of  $A$ , which does not follow from  $A$ 's natural properties, then why shouldn't it be possible for there to be one object that has wrongness, and another object with the same natural properties but without wrongness?<sup>19</sup>

That (1) is not analytic follows from my earlier argument against analytic naturalism (section 4.2), so I will grant that. (2) follows from the principle of the supervenience of moral properties. But it is not at all obvious, as Blackburn assumes, that (2) is analytic, rather than a synthetic, necessary truth. For (2) to be analytic, there must be a way of substituting synonymous expressions into (2) that results in a truth of logic. Blackburn makes no attempt to demonstrate this, nor can I see any way of doing so. Still, let us grant for the sake of argument that (2) is analytic.

What does Blackburn think is the correct, anti-realist explanation for the analyticity of (2)? He thinks that if someone were to reject supervenience, 'it would betray the whole purpose for which we moralize, which is to choose, commend, rank, approve, or forbid things on the basis of their natural properties'.<sup>20</sup> This is a very thin explanation. If we deleted 'on the basis of their natural properties' from that sentence, Blackburn would have no explanation at all. Why must we approve (etc.) things *on the basis of their natural properties*? Why, on an anti-realist view, would it be inappropriate to value things on whim, praising one action but, for no reason, condemning another, indistinguishable action? Blackburn just proposes as a brute fact that such attitudes would not count as moral.

Why, then, may not the moral realist propose the following brute fact: the concept of moral properties includes that they depend on natural properties? Even if this were all the realist had to say, his account would be no less explanatory than Blackburn's.



But the realist has available another explanation. Let us introduce the term 'good-making' as a predicate that can be applied, not to particular objects or events, but to *features* of objects or events. Good-making features are those that tend to make the thing that has them good (this is obviously related to the notion of *prima facie* rightness discussed above). For example, we can say, 'Pleasurableness is good-making'. Analogously, we can say, 'Being-an-act-of-cruelty is wrong-making'. Now here is a hypothesis: (a) Our most fundamental moral intuitions are about facts of the form '*F* is good-making', '*G* is wrong-making', and so on. When a person says that intuitively, killing is wrong, he is really reporting the intuition that being-a-killing is wrong-making. (b) To say a thing is good is to say something like: its good-making features predominate over its bad-making features, or that its *total set* of natural features is good-making.<sup>21</sup> This seems a plausible hypothesis, consistent with introspective evidence. If it is true, then it is analytic that if a thing is good, every qualitatively indistinguishable thing is also good. Analytically, the only way for a thing to be good is for its total set of natural properties to be good-making. It follows that any other object that has that total set of properties has a good-making total set of properties, and therefore is good. This gives Blackburn what he asked for: an explanation of why the supervenience of moral properties is analytic that does not imply that individual moral standards are analytic. The realist now fares better in solving Blackburn's puzzle than Blackburn himself does.

#### \*8.2.4 Jackson's objection

Frank Jackson argues that the supervenience of the moral on the non-moral is difficult to reconcile with the irreducibility of the moral. Assume that goodness supervenes on natural properties. There may be many possible ways for a thing to be good—many natural properties, that is, that would make a thing good. Let these natural properties be  $N_1$ ,  $N_2$ , and so on. For each of them, it is necessary that anything that has them is good (that is the principle of supervenience). Since we are stipulating that  $\{N_1, N_2, \dots\}$  is a *complete* list of the possible ways for a thing to be good, it is also necessary that anything that is good has at least one of these properties. Therefore, there are two predicates, 'good' and ' $N_1$  or  $N_2$  or  $\dots$ ', that apply to exactly the same things in every possible situation.<sup>22</sup> If these predicates refer to the same property, this is unproblematic. But the intuitionist holds that there are two different properties here, a natural property and a non-natural one, and that 'good' refers to the non-natural one. Jackson's objection here is subtle: what a word refers to is normally determined by its usage—what sorts of things we

apply it to, including which hypothetical situations we would apply it in. But 'good' and ' $N_1$  or  $N_2$  or . . . ' have the same usage in that sense. So, even if there were two properties there, what would make it the case that our word 'good' referred to the non-natural property, rather than the natural one? Furthermore, even if there was something that made the word refer to the non-natural property, how would children learning the language learn that 'good' was supposed to refer to the non-natural property instead of the natural one?<sup>23</sup>

I think that the answer to this is fairly straightforward for a full-blooded intuitionist. What a word refers to is determined not solely by what we apply it to, but also at least partly by speakers' *intentions*. When we think about certain kinds of events (say), we see intuitively that they have this further, evaluative property in addition to their natural properties, and we intend our word 'good' to refer to that property. We intend to refer to the supervenient property, not the subvenient one; to the property the recognition of which inherently constitutes a reason for action; to the simple property that explains what  $N_1$ ,  $N_2$ , and so on have in common. Furthermore, when children first learn the language, they take 'good' to refer to goodness rather than to ( $N_1$  or  $N_2$  or . . . ), because we assume by default that an unfamiliar word refers to the most simple, unified (as opposed to disjunctive) property consistent with its usage.

Jackson's objection really depends on a further assumption: 'Our minds do not house detectors of the nonnatural properties Mooreans believe in'. Given *this* assumption, Jackson correctly infers that 'the story about the acquisition of ethical language must be one about latching onto patterns in the naturalistic'.<sup>24</sup> Given that, it is indeed puzzling how 'good' could come to refer to anything other than some pattern of natural properties. But Jackson's assumption obviously begs the question against intuitionism, nor does he give any *argument* against the existence of ethical intuition. His argument would thus have force only against someone who posited irreducible value properties but refused to countenance either intuition or any similar faculty for knowing them.

### **\*8.2.5 An analogy: the supervenience of logical properties**

The logical properties of an argument supervene on the meanings and arrangement of the symbols it contains. This is in some respects analogous to the supervenience of value properties on non-evaluative properties. Just as it is impossible for two actions to differ in respect of rightness without differing in some natural property, so it is impossible for two arguments to differ in respect of validity without

differing in the meaning or arrangement of their symbols. Just as an action's ethical properties are *determined by* its natural properties, an argument's logical properties are determined by the meanings and arrangement of its symbols (especially the logical symbols). And just as (many philosophers believe) there is nevertheless no general algorithm for determining what is morally right, there is no general algorithm for computing what is logically necessary. For the last claim, I rely on Gödel's Theorem, assuming that we wish to count the truths of arithmetic as logically necessary.<sup>25</sup> (If you do not view truths of arithmetic as logically necessary, then substitute some notion of mathematical necessity here, and change the analogy to one of the supervenience of mathematical necessity on meanings.) This shows that these aspects of the doctrine of the supervenience of the ethical are perfectly coherent.

One disanalogy between ethics and deductive logic concerns the notion of *prima facie* rightness. There is no parallel notion of '*prima facie* validity'; the rules of deductive logic tell us that inferences of certain kinds are always valid, not that they tend to be valid. We can, however, find an analogy to *prima facie* rightness if we look to *non-demonstrative* reasoning.<sup>26</sup> It is possible that *A* non-demonstratively supports *B* but that, if certain further information, *C*, were added to one's background beliefs, *A* would no longer support *B*. We might then say that *A* is '*prima facie*' evidence for *B*, or is evidence for *B* in normal conditions. For example, relative to a normal background belief system, Jim's attesting that he owns a motorcycle is good evidence that he owns a motorcycle. But if one also knows that Jim is a pathological liar who has been falsely posing as a motorcycle gang member for years, then Jim's testimony is no longer good evidence that he owns a motorcycle. It thus seems that non-deductive logic is analogous in the relevant respects to ethics. Yet no one suggests that these features of non-deductive logic—the fact that its relations of evidential support are supervenient and that they are defeasible—support anti-realism about evidential support.

### 8.3 How can we understand 'good'?

How do we initially learn the meaning of the word 'good'?<sup>27</sup> There seem to be two ways of explaining the meaning of a word to someone. The first is to give a definition. But intuitionists deny that 'good' can be defined, so that is out. The second way is to specify some things the word applies to. For instance, one points to a number of dogs, saying 'dog', and the child gets the idea that the word refers to things of that type. One cannot point to goodness,

since goodness is not perceivable by the senses, but perhaps one may tell a child some examples of things that are good, whereupon he gets the idea that 'good' refers to what those things have in common. The problem is that people disagree substantially about what is good, so how can it be established that they all mean the same thing by 'good'?

The suggestions of the previous paragraph about how words are learned are oversimplified. Hardly any of the vast vocabulary of an ordinary person is acquired through anyone's expressly *teaching* him the words, either by defining them or by giving him lists of examples. Nearly every word is learned by one's hearing it used in conversations in which no explicit effort to explain the word is made.

In any case, there is substantial agreement on what things are good, on an everyday level. Nearly everyone calls happiness, health, friendship, knowledge, and long life 'good'. Furthermore, people tend to pursue the things they call 'good', try to get other people to pursue them, and say things implying that the 'goodness' of a thing is a reason to pursue it. Children can learn that 'good' refers to goodness because that interpretation makes sense of most of the things that are said using the word, and no other, comparably simple interpretation comes close to doing that.

A related objection is that 'good' cannot refer to any one property, since so many utterly different things are called 'good'—people, actions, states of affairs, facts, events. This is a mistake—extremely dissimilar things may still have some abstract feature in common. Compare the fact that numbers can apply to physical objects, ideas, propositions, actions, and so on—'three' means the same thing in 'I have three pairs of shoes' and 'There are three main reasons for buying a PC'. Likewise for logical properties or relationships, such as identity and set membership, or metaphysical 'properties' such as existence or determinateness. Likewise, there is no obstacle to goodness' applying to widely disparate things.

## 8.4 Is intuitionism too subjective?

Some have accused intuitionism of devolving into a form of subjectivism. Some complain that intuitionists do not provide much of a *method* for arriving at moral conclusions, or that they provide no method for distinguishing correct from incorrect intuitions.<sup>28</sup> The latter charge has been discussed previously (section 6.4). As to the absence of method, compare the 'method' by which we arrive at many physical-object beliefs: we perceive things, and then we believe things are the way we perceive them to be. This is a very simple

'method', but that does not impugn the objectivity of perceptual knowledge; no more, then, does the comparably simple intuitionist 'method' of coming by moral knowledge impugn the latter's objectivity.

Another version of the complaint is that intuitionism makes the truth of a moral theory depend upon its comporting with our intuitions and is therefore a form of subjectivism.<sup>29</sup> This is simply a misunderstanding of the theory. Intuition is our *means of cognizing* moral truths. It does not create moral truth, any more than perception creates truths about the physical world.

Still, it might be thought that intuitionism advocates a troublingly subjective epistemology, insofar as intuitions—mere internal mental states—are made the ultimate source of justification for all claims in some allegedly objective field. This objection, too, may rest on a misunderstanding: intuitionism as I understand it does not advocate appealing to intuitions as *evidence* from which to *infer* normative conclusions (see above, section 5.6). It does, however, hold that whether a moral belief is justified depends upon the believer's mental states, including his intuitions. A consequence of this is that justification is observer-relative: one person may be justified in believing what another is unjustified in believing. This, however, far from being an objectionable form of 'subjectivism', is true of all kinds of beliefs.<sup>30</sup> The justification for perceptual beliefs depends upon one's perceptual experiences. The justification for beliefs about the past depends upon one's memories. Inferential justification depends upon one's other beliefs. The fact that the justification for moral beliefs depends upon the believer's mental states is thus unsurprising and no cause for alarm.

## 8.5 Do my arguments prove too much?

Assume that my arguments against moral anti-realism succeed. Would arguments of the same kind demonstrate realism about beauty? Perhaps. Some philosophers accept aesthetic realism in any case; moreover, 'beauty' may itself be an evaluative term—'beautiful' may imply 'good'—so this result would not be terribly surprising. Here is a more troubling question: Would such arguments also demonstrate realism about *sexiness*, *funniness*, and *coolness* (as in, 'The Matrix is a cool movie')? Realism about such properties is considerably less attractive than realism about value.<sup>31</sup>

To start with, consider non-cognitivism. Since sentences like 'I believe that Steven is funny' and 'If Steven is funny, then the audience will laugh' make sense and are sometimes appropriately

asserted, it seems that non-cognitivism about funniness faces more or less the same problems as non-cognitivism about value. The linguistic arguments will probably work in exactly the same way, with about equal plausibility, in the case of *any* sentences that take the grammatical form of assertions, for any such sentences will probably be able to be embedded in larger sentences, just as evaluative claims can be. No intuitions specifically about the nature of funniness are required to make this argument.

The argument against 'nihilism' about funniness also seems analogous to the argument against value nihilism: the argument would consist in the display of some paradigmatically funny things, things that almost everyone would laugh at. Some searching might be required, since senses of humor vary, but let's assume we find such a paradigm.<sup>32</sup> Suppose it is this joke:

An engineer, a scientist, a mathematician, and a philosopher are off in Ireland together, when they see a black sheep alone in a field. The engineer says, 'Hey, it looks like the sheep around here are black'. The scientist looks at him skeptically and replies, 'Well, at least *some* of them are'. Then the mathematician gives them another skeptical look and says, 'Well, at least *one* of them is'. Finally, the philosopher turns to them and says, 'Well, at least *on one side*'.

Pretend that upon hearing that, everyone laughs uproariously (including you). I invite you to agree that it was funny. How absurd it would be for the nihilist to claim, because of some dubious philosophical theory, that the joke wasn't funny!

Still, we might well feel humor nihilism to be less problematic than value nihilism. Giving up funniness assertions would involve a minor change to our belief systems. We won't have to stop laughing at things, since laughter is not a belief, nor is it caused or 'justified' by beliefs about funniness.

I would rather not deny that the above joke is funny. It seems funny to me. Perhaps our best bet is a subjectivist theory of funniness. Let's review the problems with value subjectivism from chapter 3 and see whether they apply to humor subjectivism:

- i) *The Problem of Horrible Attitudes*: Imagine someone whose sense of humor diverges radically from ours (but not in a way that might be *morally* offensive, such as laughing at another's suffering). He goes outside and sees an ordinary stick, whereupon he breaks into hysterical laughter. The subjectivist says: 'For him, the stick is

funny'. This does not seem obviously wrong, in the way that 'For Ted Bundy, murder is permissible' is obviously wrong.

On the other hand, some would likely describe this person as follows: 'He laughs at things that aren't funny'. Perhaps in this context, 'is funny' means approximately, 'would tend to make typical people laugh'. This implies that, if most of us are disposed to laugh at sticks, then sticks are funny. Again, this does not seem unacceptable in the way that 'If most of us approve of slavery, then slavery is good' is.

ii) *The Problem of Disagreement*: After hearing the same joke, one person says, 'That was funny', and another says, 'That was not funny'. The subjectivist says they are not disagreeing: one of them just means the joke was funny to him, while the other says it wasn't funny to *him*. This is not implausible. The sentence 'The joke is funny to me' makes sense, and the first person may well be willing to agree that that was what he meant. He is very unlikely to insist that the second person is *wrong*, nor to present arguments to show that the joke was funny, unless perhaps to say that most people would laugh at it. In contrast, the sentence, 'Abortion is wrong to me' does not make sense and cannot be substituted for 'Abortion is wrong'. If someone says 'Abortion is not wrong', pro-lifers will say he is mistaken and will give arguments to show that abortion is wrong. Their arguments will not appeal to the claim that most people disapprove of abortion.

iii) *The Problem of Arbitrariness*: We argued that value subjectivism makes the attitudes or commands of the relevant person or group arbitrary. Such questions as 'Why should we obey arbitrary rules?' and 'How would someone's approving of *x* for no reason make *x* good?' then seem appropriate. Humor subjectivism, likewise, makes our laughter arbitrary—not in the sense that it cannot be causally explained, but in the sense that it cannot be *justified*. But this is not disturbing at all, in the way that arbitrariness in ethics would be. The question 'Why should we laugh at that joke?' does not naturally arise, and 'How would our being disposed to laugh at *x* for no reason make *x* funny?' seems unconvincing—we do not generally expect people to have *reasons* (that is, justifications) for laughter, in the sense that we might have reasons for our actions.

iv) *The Problem of Fallibility*: Fallibilism about humor likewise seems unconvincing. Suppose someone says, 'I find that joke funny, but I could be mistaken'. I find it hard to understand this—unless the speaker is referring to what most people would laugh at, or something of the sort. (Imagine someone who runs a comedy club trying to decide whom to hire for the evening's entertainment. He

finds Sally funny, but later decides he was mistaken about her funniness when the audience merely groans.)

It seems, then, that humor subjectivism is far more defensible than moral subjectivism.

One further point. Many examples of ‘obviously subjective’ properties may have evaluative components, and this will stymie any attempt to give them purely subjectivist analyses. ‘If baby-killing impressed a lot of people, then baby-killing would be cool’ is false because baby-killing is *bad*, and ‘cool’ implies ‘good’ (whatever else it implies). Similarly, in some cases, a person may argue that something is ‘not funny’ on moral grounds—for instance, that it is inappropriate to laugh at a thing because doing so would offend others or express a bad attitude. Perhaps ‘funny’ implies ‘not bad to laugh at’. ‘Sexy’ may similarly imply ‘not bad (or abnormal) to feel sexual attraction towards’. If this is so, then of course these concepts will resist purely subjectivist treatments, but that would not pose a challenge to the arguments of this book.

## 8.6 Evolution and ethics

### 8.6.1 The evolutionary objection to realism

Sociobiologists (or ‘evolutionary psychologists’, in the current lingo) have offered explanations for moral behavior and moral beliefs, in terms of the theory of evolution. Since evolution generally leads us to expect selfishness, the main problem has been taken to be that of explaining why we often help others at some cost to ourselves. Proffered partial explanations include:

*Kin selection:* We help members of our own families, often at great expense to ourselves, because family members share many of the same genes. Helping one’s family is thus an indirect way of increasing the reproduction of one’s genes.

*Reciprocal altruism:* We help others because doing so tends to make them want to help us in return. Harming others or breaking agreements with them tends to make them angry and make them want to harm us.

*Reputation effects:* We behave nicely because doing so improves our general reputation in our community, causing others to regard us as good trading partners, and so on. One who breaks agreements or attacks people is likely to be widely shunned.<sup>33</sup>



Sociobiologists do not say that we go through the above kinds of reasoning before deciding what to do, but rather that these arguments explain why our feelings of wanting to be nice to each other have reproductive value.

Some say that evolutionary theory's ability to explain our moral beliefs undermines moral realism, particularly ethical intuitionism. There are three arguments for this.<sup>34</sup>

*First:* Since sociobiology provides adequate explanations for our moral beliefs, and these explanations do not appeal to objective values, there is no *need* to posit objective values. They do not help us explain anything, and our overall theory is simpler without them. Nor need we posit a special cognitive faculty of moral intuition, when we could explain moral beliefs by appeal to emotions, which in turn are explained evolutionarily.

*Second:* Even if there are objective values, the evolutionary explanation of our moral beliefs gives us no reason to expect that our intuitions would tend to correspond to the moral truth. This stands in contrast to other cognitive faculties. An organism with poor vision will fare worse in terms of survival and reproduction than an organism with accurate vision. A person who mistakes tigers for peach trees will have diminished survival prospects. But we have no account of how reproductive fitness would be enhanced by correct *moral* beliefs.

*Third:* Not only do we lack an account of why we should tend to have correct moral beliefs, but the sociobiological account of moral beliefs provides positive grounds for expecting our moral beliefs *not* to be reliable, assuming there is an objective moral truth. This is because evolution would tend to give us strong biases in favor of ourselves, our kin, and members of our own social group. Evolution would mold our moral attitudes towards its own purposes, to ensure behavior that increases reproductive fitness, regardless of what is actually morally right.

The first argument suggests that there are no objective values. The latter two suggest that, even if there are, we have no way of knowing about them.

### 8.6.2 The realist's burden

It is important to remember that intuitionists do not say that we have a 'special moral sense', that is, a separate faculty dedicated solely to cognizing moral truths. Intuition is a function of *reason*. Moral intuition differs from mathematical intuition in the way that perceptions of cars differ from perceptions of trees—that is, merely in

having different objects. There is thus no special explanation required for how 'the faculty of moral intuition' evolved.

Consider an analogous case: why do we have the ability to see stars? After all, our evolutionary ancestors presumably would have done just as well if they only saw things on Earth. Of course, this is a silly question. We can see the stars because we have vision, which is useful for seeing things on Earth, and once you have vision, you wind up seeing whatever is there sending light in your direction, whether it is a useful thing to see or not. Likewise, once you have intelligence, you wind up apprehending the sorts of things that can be known by reason, whether they are useful to know or not. Thus, humans are capable of learning to play chess at an incredibly sophisticated level, despite that the environment of *Australopithecus* contained no chess boards. If some evaluative truths can be known through reason, we would likely know them whether they were useful to know or not.<sup>35</sup>

Note that moral theory does not need to be positively validated by the theory of evolution, any more than any other branch of knowledge does. In order to know that  $2+2=4$ , we do not have to first consult the sociobiologists and see whether evolution predicts that humans would have correct mathematical beliefs.<sup>36</sup> In order to know that there is a computer before me, I do not have to first see whether evolution predicts that humans would have correct physical-object beliefs. This is fortunate, since if this *were* a requirement, we could gain no knowledge of the physical world before we knew the theory of evolution, in which case we would have no way of verifying that theory to begin with. We have seen that some moral beliefs can reasonably be taken as foundational, just as some mathematical and perceptual beliefs can. The initial justification for beliefs about moral facts does not derive from their fitting into a sociobiological explanation, nor from the ability of moral facts to explain natural facts.

The anti-realist thus should not argue against realism on the ground that sociobiology *fails to predict* that we would have moral knowledge. That argument would be no more plausible than the argument that we should reject arithmetic because sociobiology fails to predict that we would have knowledge of it. But the anti-realist *may* argue that sociobiology predicts that we would *not* have moral knowledge. Here, the assumption would not be that morality needs outside validation, but only that it can be undermined by its tension with other justified beliefs. Therefore, in my following replies, I need only argue that the theory of evolution does not determinately predict absence of moral knowledge.

### 8.6.3 How good are evolutionary accounts of ethics?

Evolutionary explanations of ethics are unimpressive—certainly not impressive enough that their existence justifies making a radical revision of our belief system and rejecting all moral beliefs.

What would be an ‘impressive’ set of explanations? First, it would be one that promised specific explanations for all the major ethical intuitions, including the ones that are the *most* plausible examples of rational principles. It should explain intuitions about such things as the supervenience of value, universalizability, the asymmetry and transitivity of ‘better than’, rights, and the Categorical Imperative. It should promise us explanations for the *details* of our intuitions about particular situations, such as the seemingly divergent intuitions in the trolley car problem and the organ-harvesting example.<sup>37</sup> With few exceptions, evolutionary explanations of ethics purport to explain moral behavior only in the vaguest outlines, taking morality to consist of little more specific than the imperative, ‘Cooperate’. The only relatively specific moral beliefs that sociobiologists have so far explained are the ones that initially seem the most tailor-made for evolutionary explanation and the worst candidates for rational moral beliefs—for example, moral beliefs about incest, special obligations to family, and reproductive practices.<sup>38</sup>

Second, it would be a set of explanations that implied unique, or at least fairly specific predictions about the content of morality. That is, it should be evident that the explanatory framework being used could *not* accommodate a vast range of different moral beliefs and behaviors, but requires moral beliefs to take fairly specific forms—so that the hypothesis that moral beliefs are evolved adaptations would have been falsified if we had had very different moral intuitions from those we actually have. For instance, we would like an explanatory framework that could explain why the Golden Rule would be accepted but could *not* accommodate widespread acceptance of egoism (given that egoism is contrary to our moral intuitions).

Why impose this requirement? Michael Ruse is arguing that the availability of evolutionary explanations of ethics is compelling evidence against moral realism. But if evolutionary explanations of ethics would most likely have been available *whether or not* realism was true—say, because one can think of an evolutionary explanation for virtually anything—then the fact that they are available is not significant evidence against realism.

Many have complained that sociobiology is ‘unfalsifiable’.<sup>39</sup> My claim is weaker: I am not criticizing sociobiology *in general*, nor am I claiming that the idea of an evolutionary explanation for ethical

beliefs could not be falsified by any evidence. My claim is that there is such a wide range of conceivable ethical beliefs that could be given an evolutionary explanation, that the fact that our actual ethical beliefs are susceptible to one (if they are) does not tell us much. If we had had a widespread intuition that ethical egoism was true (the right action is always the action that best serves one's own interests), wouldn't sociobiologists have laid claim to a rather straightforward explanation for this? But our actual moral intuitions (on this one dimension of egoism vs. altruism) are nearly the opposite. If sociobiologists can explain this too, then the range of moral beliefs they could in principle accommodate is very wide. To give a more extreme example of the flexibility of the paradigm, some sociobiologists have even claimed homosexuality to be an adaptation.<sup>40</sup> If even homosexuality can be fit into the sociobiological paradigm, it is unsurprising that some moral beliefs can be.

#### **8.6.4 An evolutionary account of moral perception**

On my account, the correct explanation for why we have ethical intuition will refer to whatever is the explanation for why we have reason and intelligence in general. However, I now want to set that point aside and suggest that there is an additional evolutionary explanation available for why people should have correct ethical beliefs. This explanation requires four assumptions:

- a) A moral system fairly takes account of everyone's interests. This is not all there is to morality, but it is one (perhaps analytically) necessary aspect of morality. A system of rules that ignored interests, or that took account of some interests while arbitrarily excluding others, would not be a moral system. There are different possible ways of fairly taking account of interests, of course—for instance, consequentialist ways and rights-based ways. I won't try to analyze 'fair' here, but it is to be understood as a contrast to 'biased'.
- b) Peaceful cooperation provides benefits to all that generally outweigh any benefits that could be gained by exploitation of others. Conflict with others causes harms that generally outweigh any benefits that might be non-cooperatively extracted. Suppose you have \$100 that I want. I decide to go to your house and take it, whereupon a fight ensues. Since I am stronger, I win the fight and get the \$100. However, I suffer a broken arm in the process, a harm much worse than the loss of \$100. You are even worse off than I am (with two broken arms, say), but this is irrelevant; my goal was to benefit myself, not to hurt you, so I have failed.

- c) Peaceful cooperation requires an agreed-upon set of rules. If I am operating under rules that assign ownership of that \$100 to me, while you are operating under rules that assign ownership of the same \$100 to you, then a conflict is likely to ensue. If the two of us are trying to cooperate in some endeavor, but we have very different understandings of what each of us is required to do, then our cooperation is likely to break down.
- d) Agreement on a set of social rules is unlikely unless those rules fairly take into account everyone's interests. If I am operating under rules that are biased in my favor, then I am unlikely to find anyone who agrees with them. To achieve peaceful cooperation with others, I need to accept rules that fairly take into account both my and their interests.

This doesn't yet get us to the correct set of moral rules. My suggestion, however, is that people with a capacity for moral intuition would enjoy the advantage of agreeing with each other on a set of rules that permits social cooperation, since it fairly takes account of everyone's interests. This is not the only way that such coordination might be achieved, but it is one way. People lacking accurate moral intuition might see no reason to accept a set of social rules, or might be inclined to accept a set of rules skewed in their own favor. Even if they accepted sets of rules that fairly took account of everyone's interests, it is likely that they would still not agree, since there are many possible such sets of rules. Since there is only one truth, those with accurate moral perception avoid this problem.<sup>41</sup>

My claims for this explanation are modest. Perhaps it is roughly correct; perhaps not. In any case, it shows that it is possible for accurate moral perception to have survival value.

I do not deny that sociobiology can teach us something about ethics. As noted, evolution may have endowed us with biases that affect our moral judgments. Sociobiology can help us identify these biases, and so correct for them, thereby improving our moral cognition.

## 8.7 Is intuitionism too revisionary?

Given that current moral beliefs and practices can be expected to correspond strongly with our moral intuitions, it is natural to assume that intuitionism leads to very conservative ethical views. But this need not be so. Consider the analogous case of our knowledge of the external world. Science tells us that the sun is 1.3 million times larger than the Earth, that invisible force fields fill all of space, and that

ordinary material objects are composed of tiny, colorless particles in rapid motion, with great spaces between them. These conclusions are surprising and quite far from the way things appear to casual observation. Yet scientists do not possess some new cognitive faculty that common folk are deprived of; science is based, solely or primarily, on observation.

Similarly, moral reasoning might lead to surprising and revisionary conclusions, despite that this reasoning must ultimately be based on intuition. An intuitionist will accept intuitions as a source of *prima facie* justification, but he should not accept intuitions *uncritically*, any more than a scientist accepts apparent observations uncritically. As we saw in chapter 6, there are many ways our intuitions and beliefs can go wrong, and the wise intuitionist will be on guard against these sources of error.

From the intuitionist perspective, there is good reason to believe that a revisionary moral theory is in fact called for. Many commonly held moral beliefs look more like products of self-interest, cultural indoctrination, or the imperatives of natural selection than like products of careful, rational reflection.<sup>42</sup> For example, the widespread belief that polygamy is wrong apparently derives from our particular culture.<sup>43</sup> Most cultures have practiced polygamy without considering it wrong at all, and few who hold the belief that polygamy is wrong can offer any plausible reasons for that judgment; nor is the wrongness of polygamy the sort of thing we would expect to simply be a fundamental evaluative truth, incapable of further explanation. Likewise, few are prepared to give any rational account of the alleged wrongness of incest; most of us, it seems, just *feel* that it is wrong.<sup>44</sup> Some have speculated that this has an evolutionary explanation, relating to the increased risk of birth defects resulting from incest.<sup>45</sup> And the widespread belief that, while killing human beings for food is one of the most heinous wrongs imaginable, killing members of any other species for food is not even slightly wrong, seems more easily explained by self-interest, culture, and/or natural selection than by rational insight. Again, the belief hardly seems like an axiomatic evaluative truth, yet most who hold it are unable to advance any credible reasons for it.<sup>46</sup> Anti-realists take all this as evidence against moral realism;<sup>47</sup> intuitionists, however, will simply take it as reason to reject the particular moral beliefs in question.

It would take us too far afield to discuss the merits of these and other common moral beliefs here. But suppose it turns out that reflection by the most careful and thorough of intuitionists leads them to deny a great many, perhaps the majority of commonly held moral beliefs. We might then worry that intuitionism is *too* revision-

ary. The rough idea I have in mind here is this: The meanings of (all or most of) the words in our language, including 'wrong' and 'permissible', are determined by how they are typically used by those who speak the language. For this reason, it cannot be the case that a word is *normally* misused; a sufficiently common 'misuse' of a term simply generates a new meaning for the term. By the same token, a person who uses a word radically differently (in the sense of applying it to a very different class of things) from how it is ordinarily used may be accused of simply misunderstanding the word. Thus, imagine someone who denies that such animals as German shepherds, poodles, and Scotch terriers are dogs; instead, he says, they are *chairs*. This person would rightly be accused, on these grounds alone, of misunderstanding the word 'chair'. This is not to deny that people who understand the term 'chair' can sometimes mistake non-chair items for chairs. But a person cannot understand the English word 'chair' and yet consistently take it to apply to a very different kind of object from that to which most English speakers apply it. One might say: it cannot turn out that German shepherds are chairs, because that is just not what we mean by 'chair'.

Similarly, I imagine an anti-realist arguing as follows:

1. If intuitionism is true, then wrongness exists and is an objective property that we are aware of by rational intuition. (Premise.)
2. There is no objective property that we are aware of by rational intuition, that most of the things people typically call 'wrong' have in common. (Premise.)
3. Therefore, if intuitionism is true, then wrongness exists, but most of the things people typically call 'wrong' do not have it. (From 1, 2.)
4. It cannot be the case that wrongness exists but that most of the things people typically call 'wrong' do not have it. (Premise.)
5. Therefore, intuitionism is false. (From 3, 4.)

Premise (1) simply restates (part of) the theory of ethical intuitionism. Premise (2) is supported by the fact that people—on the basis of emotions and other non-rational causes—commonly judge actions to be 'wrong' that do not appear to have any relevant objective feature in common. Premise (4) is supported by the general conception of language just discussed, according to which the meaning of a word is normally determined by its use.<sup>48</sup>

How should an intuitionist respond? The first problem is that the argument for premise (4) elides an important distinction between two senses in which a word might be 'misused'. In the first and more

proper sense, a word is misused when it is used to mean something that it does not mean according to the conventions of the language. For example, in the sentence, 'In saying that he would not raise taxes on the middle class, the President inferred that he might raise taxes on other groups', the word 'inferred' is incorrectly used to mean 'implied'. In the second sense, a word might be said to be 'misused' when, roughly, it is applied to something that does not have the property the word refers to. For example, in the sentence, 'Elizabeth Proctor is a witch', the word 'witch' is incorrectly applied to Proctor, who is not in fact a witch. It is not, however, misused in the first sense—it is not used to mean something that the word does not normally mean. Now, it is true, for the reason stated above (that usage determines words' meanings), that a word cannot be generally misused *in the first sense*. But as the example of the word 'witch' shows, a word *can* be generally misused in the second sense; indeed, the word 'witch' has been misused in *this sense every* time it has been applied to anyone—for as I assume, there are no witches. Similarly, then, it is conceivable that the word 'wrong' is commonly 'misused' in the sense of being applied to things that do not have the property of wrongness—though not, of course, in the sense of being used to mean something that it does not normally mean. Thus, premise (4) seems to be false; at any rate, it is not supported by the mere fact that word meanings are generally determined by usage.

Still, I do not think that the charge that intuitionism is too revisionary is entirely without plausibility. While the objection we have been discussing fails to show that it is conceptually incoherent to attribute massive moral error to people, it may nevertheless be true that the meaning of 'wrong' in English is such as to preclude the possibility of the kind of error I have hypothesized. Perhaps most people's understanding of the word is so closely tied to such supposed paradigms of wrongness as incest, polygamy, and cleaning the toilet with the national flag<sup>49</sup> that it is analytically true that, if wrongness exists at all, then those actions have it. Perhaps, at the same time, most people's understanding of 'wrong' is sufficiently loosely tied to the notion of reasons for action that the fact (if this is a fact) that there exist sufficient all-things-considered reasons for not eating non-human animals does *not* suffice to establish that such eating is wrong. I say 'perhaps' because, while I do not believe these things are the case, I am not sure that they aren't. And so I want to address the question of how an intuitionist should react if these things *are* the case and if, at the same time, reflection reveals no relevant objective property that incest, polygamy, and cleaning the toilet with the flag have in common.



Briefly, I think an intuitionist could, without rendering his position uninteresting, accept the charge of using some words, such as 'morally right' and 'morally wrong', in non-standard senses. I intend my use of the word 'wrong' to refer, roughly speaking, to the property about which (most of) the following are true: it is objective; it is not a physical property; only intentional actions can have it; murder, theft, the breaking of promises, and other actions that harm others or violate others' rights typically have it; when an action has it, there are sufficient all-things-considered reasons against performing that action; guilt and remorse are typical and appropriate reactions to the awareness that an action of one's own had it; blame is a typical and appropriate response to the awareness that an action of someone else's had it; an action has it only if the agent could have refrained from performing that action; an action cannot have it if the action is permissible, praiseworthy, or obligatory. When I say that polygamy is not wrong, I mean that polygamy has no feature of which all or most of those things are true.

The most important of the conditions is that wrong actions are actions that there are sufficient, objective reasons not to perform. The core of my intuitionism is the claim that we can sometimes see, intuitively, objective reasons for action, reasons that do not depend on any contingent desires or other psychological responses of ours. If it turns out, as might be the case, that a sufficiently large number of English speakers do not use the word 'wrong' even roughly this way—perhaps because they do not understand ' $x$  is wrong' to imply that there are sufficient reasons not to do  $x$ , or because they understand merely subjective reasons as counting towards an action's wrongness—then I would perhaps agree to a change of terminology. Perhaps, instead of 'ethical intuitionism', I should call the theory I have been defending 'evaluative intuitionism' or 'intuitionism about practical reasons'.